

Transitive and Intransitive English Verbs

A Quick Reference Guide

The goal here is to see how the English language has developed to function in the way that it does, with two words for each "sensation." The main pattern is that more detail is *customary* in spatial descriptions and with private thoughts and feelings. The answer to the question of *why* (or *how*) this added detail is customary may be that these details are clearly practical in these contexts.

What kind of word?	"Intransitive"	"Transitive"	
Is detail optional?	detail is required	details are optional:	
Use of Preposition:	must use a preposition	can be used without a preposition	Sometimes can be used with a preposition
Function of using or not using details.	A: private thoughts and feelings; subtle topics.	Simple, binary (yes or no). (Details not needed.)	Adding optional detail, usually not needed or added.
	B: details of physical space		

Non-Directional Personal & Directional Spatial				
Sense / Category	Word	Directional	Transitive / Intransitive (w/o preposition) / (w/preposition) Binary / detailed	External / Personal
hearing/ vibration	hear	not directional	Transitive	external
	listen (to)	not directional	Intransitive	personal
Learning	Study/Practice	not directional	Transitive	external
	Learn (to)	not directional	Intransitive	personal
Obtain/Want	have / get	not directional	Transitive	external
	want (to)/yearn (to)	not directional	Intransitive	personal
Think	analyze/calculate	not directional	Transitive	external
	think (about)	not directional	Intransitive	personal
light/sight	see	Directional	Transitive	personal
	look (for)	Directional	Intransitive	external
[point/focus]	point (to)	Directional	Intransitive	external
	focus (on)	Directional	Intransitive	personal
Movement	go (to)	Directional	Intransitive	external

Ancillary & Non-Directional				
General	sense	not directional	Transitive	-
Physical Contact:	touch	not directional	Transitive	external
	feel	not directional	Transitive	personal
Molecular:	taste	not directional	Transitive	personal
	smell	not directional	Transitive	-

Transitive and Intransitive English Verbs - Blurb

A Quick Reference Guide

People often ask, *why* there are two words: "see" and "look," "hear" and "listen."

One way of describing the difference between *transitive* and *intransitive* verbs, in English is that they are different kinds of words that naturally take two different functions.

External vs. Personal

A transitive word is more simple: "I hear you."

An intransitive word describes a relationship involving a preposition, with more flexibility in the meaning:

"I will listen to you."

"I will listen for you." (trying to find "you")

"I will listen over you." (hearing other people, not "you")

"I will listen after you."

Intransitive verbs (verbs that need a preposition) often involve what an individual person or character thinks, wants, feels, intends, and tries, not simply what can be observed mechanically.

You often cannot detect the "internal" processes around intransitive verbs. You can tell if someone hears a bell. You usually cannot tell if someone is "listening for" a bell while they are doing something else, any more than you can tell if they clearly, or ambiguously, or ambivalently, wish to, want to, intend to, try to, or pretend to, fearfully, or eagerly, anticipate the bell.

In the same way, the transitive word describes what you can observe "factually" from the outside, and the intransitive (preposition using) words tend to describe what you usually cannot see concretely as an outside observer. For example, someone can pretend to be surprised or not surprised. Someone cannot pretend to hear the ring and pick up the phone.

Ethics:

There is also an ethical or practical aspect to this. You can ask someone to look, but you cannot ask them to see. You can ask them to listen, but you can't ask them to hear. You can ask them to study. You cannot ask them to learn. You can, however, *hope* that someone hears, sees, and learns.

Spatial Context:

The main "exception" to the "internal" pattern falls into another main pattern, descriptions of physical three dimensional space, where the "external" description *should* have a preposition in order to be clear. For example, the statement "You need to ~~go the bridge~~." does not contain enough information to be fully practical when describing what a physical action is, should be, needs to be, was requested to be, etc.

Example:

The sentence (fragment) "~~You need to go the bridge~~." does not have all the needed information:

You need to go to the bridge.

You need to go from the bridge.

You need to go over the bridge.

You need to go under the bridge.

You need to go partially across the bridge.

You need to go on the bridge.

You need to go behind the bridge.

You need to go around the bridge.

You need to go for the bridge. (To **obtain** the bridge. / To **benefit** the bridge. To go **towards** the bridge.)